



文 25 languages

Article Talk

Read Edit View history Tools ▾

From Wikipedia, the free encyclopedia

Not to be confused with [Circumflex](#).

A **circumfix** (abbr: circ)^[1] (also **parafix**,^[2] **confix**, or **ambifix**) is an **affix** which has two parts, one placed at the start of a word, and the other at the end. Circumfixes contrast with **prefixes**, attached to the beginnings of words; **suffixes**, attached at the end; and **infixes**, inserted in the middle. Circumfixes are common in **Malay**^[3] and **Georgian**.^[4]

Its related operation is called **circumfixation** (or **parafixation**, **confixation**, **ambifixation**).

Examples [\[edit \]](#)

>Angle brackets< are used to mark off circumfixes.

Germanic languages [\[edit \]](#)

The circumfix is probably most widely known from the [German past participle](#), which is *ge-*...*-t* (*ge-* prefix + *-t* suffix) for regular verbs. The verb *spiel-en*, for example, has the participle *ge-spiel-t*.^[5] However, a number of so-called [strong verbs](#) display the suffix *-en* (*ge-sung-en* 'sung'), while all verbs carrying non-initial stress come without the prefix part *ge-*, as in *telefonier-t* 'telephoned'.

Dutch has a similar system (*spel-en* → *ge-speel-d* in this case). In Dutch, the circumfix *ge->...<-te* (ge- prefix + -te suffix) can be used to form certain **collective nouns** (*berg* (mountain) → *ge-berg-te* (mountain range)).

East Asian languages [\[edit \]](#)

In [Japanese](#), some linguists consider *o->...<-ni naru* (o- [honorific prefix](#) + ni particle + verb *naru*) and *o->...<-suru* (o- prefix + *-suru* suffix/verb *suru*) to be [honorific](#) circumfixes,^[6] for example *yom-u* ('read') ... → *o->yom-i<-ni naru* (respectful), *o->yom-i<-suru* (humble).

In addition, Old Japanese had a prohibitive construction *na*->... <*-so₂(ne)* (where the bracketed *ne* is optional), which at least **one linguist** ([ja](#)) considers to be a circumfixal word form; an example using the Old Japanese verb 'write' (*kak-u*) would be *na*->*kak-i₁* <-*so₂(ne)*. The form without the bracketed *ne* survived marginally into Early Middle Japanese, but has no equivalent in any modern Japanese dialect or any other Japonic language. Instead, all modern Japonic languages and dialects express the prohibitive with a *suffixal* particle *na* (which is probably related to the prefixal part of the Old Japanese construction) attached to a non-past form of the verb; e.g., Tōkyō Japanese *kāku-na*, [Kyōto Japanese](#) *kāku-na*, [Kagoshima Japanese](#) *ka ɾ-nā* or *kan-nā*, [Hachijō](#) *kaku-na*, Yamatohama [Amami](#) *kʰakʰu-na*, Nakijin [Kunigami](#) *həkʰu-nā*, Shuri [Okinawan](#) *kaku-nā*, Irabu [Miyakoan](#) *kafi-na*, Hateruma [Yaeyaman](#) *həkʰu-na*, and [Yonaguni](#) *kʰagu-n-na* (all 'don't write!'). In addition to the circumfixal forms, Old Japanese also had a suffixal form similar to the modern forms (e.g., *kak-u-na*), as well as a *prefixal* form *na-kak-i₁*, which is also not reflected in any modern Japonic variety.

Austronesian languages [\[edit \]](#)

Malay has eight circumfixes:

per-⟩...⟨-kan

per- > ... < -i

ber-...<-an

ke- > ... < -an

pen- > ... < -an

per- > ... < -an

se-⟩...⟨-nya

 $ke-\rangle \dots \langle -i$

For example, the circumfix *ke-...-an* can be added to the root *adil* "fair/just" to form *ke-adil-an* "fairness/justice".^[7]

Other languages [[edit](#)]

In most North African and some Levantine [varieties of Arabic](#), verbs are negated by placing the circumfix *ma*⋯*š* around the verb together with all its prefixes and suffixed direct- and indirect-object pronouns. For example, [Egyptian](#) *bitgibuhum-laha* "you bring them to her" is negated as *ma*⋯*bitgibuhum-lahā*⋯*š* "you don't bring them to her".

In [Berber languages](#) the feminine is marked with the circumfix >...<t. The word *aɸus* "hand" becomes >aɸus<t. In *Kabyle*, <θ>issli<θ "bride" derives from *issli* "groom". From *bni*, to build, with >...<t we obtain *tbnit* "thou buildest".

Negation in **Guaraní** is also done with circumfixes, *nd>...<i* and *nd>...<mo'ãi* for **future** negation.

In some [Slavic languages](#), and in [Hungarian](#), the [superlative](#) of adjectives is formed with a circumfix. For example, in [Czech](#), the circumfix *nej*>...<*ší* is used – *mladý* "young" becomes *nejmladší* "youngest". The corresponding circumfix in Hungarian is *leg*>...<*bb*, as in *legnagyobb* "biggest", from *nagy* "big". (In both cases, the [comparative](#) form is produced using the suffix without the prefix: *mladší* "younger"; *nagyobb* "bigger".)

In **Gurmanchema** and **Wolof**, noun classes are indicated by circumfix.

See also [\[edit \]](#)

- Circumposition
- Silent (or magic) *e*, a discontinuous digraph in English
- Epenthesis

References [\[edit \]](#)

1. ^ Comrie, Bernard; Haspelmath, Martin; Bickel, Balthasar (2008). "Leipzig glossing rules: Conventions for interlinear morpheme-by-morpheme glosses" [↗](#). Archived from [the original](#) [↗](#) on 2019-08-04. Retrieved 2016-04-12.
2. ^ *The Oxford Handbook of Language Production* (by Matthew Goldrick, Victor Ferreira, Michele Miozzo), [Oxford University Press](#), 2014, ISBN 9780199393459, [p. 159](#) [↗](#) at [Google Books](#): "Circumfixation (or parafixation) is the most sparsely attested type of affixation, [...]"
3. ^ Tadmor, Uri (2005), "Malay-Indonesian and Malayic languages", in Strazny, Philipp (ed.), *Encyclopedia of Linguistics*, New York: Fitzroy Dearborn, pp. 644–647
4. ^ [Colarusso, John](#) (2005), "Georgian and Caucasian languages", in Strazny, Philipp (ed.), *Encyclopedia of Linguistics*, New York: Fitzroy Dearborn, pp. 380–383
5. ^ Zingler, Tim (15 March 2022). "Circumfixation: A semasiological approach" [↗](#). *Word Structure*. **15**: 55–113. doi:10.3366/word.2022.0199 [↗](#). S2CID 247488121 [↗](#). Retrieved 29 November 2022.
6. ^ Boeckx, Cedric; Niinuma, Fumikazu (2004), "Conditions on Agreement in Japanese", *Natural Language and Linguistic Theory*, **22** (3): 453–480, doi:10.1023/B:NALA.0000027669.59667.c5 [↗](#), S2CID 170936045 [↗](#)
7. ^ Baryadi, I. Praptomo (2011). *Morfologi dalam Ilmu Bahasa* (in Indonesian). Yogyakarta: Sanata Dharma University Publishers. pp. 42–43.

External links [[edit](#)]

- [Circumfixes by language](#) on Wiktionary

Category: Affixes

This page was last edited on 27 May 2025, at 05:54 (UTC).

Text is available under the [Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 License](#); additional terms may apply. By using this site, you agree to the [Terms of Use](#) and [Privacy Policy](#). Wikipedia® is a registered trademark of the [Wikimedia Foundation, Inc.](#), a non-profit organization.